enrichment. This chapter challenges this dichotomy, questioning ethnicity as a framework for understanding the Kachin conflict, but without adopting simplistic greed-based alternative explanations.

Nationalist movements and counter-movements in Myanmar employ 'ethnic identity' as the key means of framing identification and political mobilization, but this chapter finds that conceptually these rigid categories are detrimental to peace processes — observations in tune with previous findings about the Moldovan conflict in Transnistria (Laoutides 2008). Recent comparative literature on 'ethnic conflict' suggests the flattening of conflict into an 'ethnic' label implicates all members of a given collectivity in the conflict and interpolates elements into a unified whole, erasing or ignoring distinctions and difference (Murer 2012). This chapter departs from a treatment of social groups in the Kachin conflict as distinct social categories, refocusing attention on how power is framed and contested in relation to processes of identification (Malešević 2006). It concludes that 'ethnicity' has become the outward manifestation of a conflict far more deeply underpinned by issues of political rights and distribution, state power versus decentralization, the quest for equality and freedom, and the question of who constitutes the demos in Myanmar's future democracy. Control over territory is seen to be both instrumental and strongly symbolic, a powerful tool for building a nationalistic sense of identity and a sine qua non condition for survival in the global international political context of sovereign states (Bartelson 2014). As such, this chapter concludes that engagement with the peace process needs to move beyond focus on the 'ethnicity' and 'ethnic dialogue' framework to address these underlying drivers of conflict.

The chapter consists of a series of theoretical discussions based on key observations made during our 2014 fieldwork. It is divided into seven sections. The first explores the problematic practice of framing conflict in Myanmar around ethnicity. The second considers the instrumental adoption of historical narratives in the construction of this nationalism. The third section explores the widely accepted primary cause of inequality, while the fourth uses this framework to analyse whether the root cause of the conflict is more about identity or ideology. The fifth and sixth sections then apply this analysis to the roles of territory and resources respectively, and to the return to conflict by the KIO/A in 2011. A concluding section explores the implications of this analysis for sustainable peace to be able to emerge from the political dialogue process.